

STERILE MEDICAL KITS

Influenced by Lister's ideas, doctors began boiling their surgical instruments to sterilize them (get rid of germs) before operations. In 1886, the American industrialist Robert Wood Johnson and his brothers founded a pharmaceutical company, called Johnson & Johnson, to make sterile bandages and surgical equipment. After two years, they began manufacturing the world's first commercial first-aid kits, bringing sterile medical care to the masses.

Medicines and sterile bandages are stored in compartments in the kit.



First-aid kit, c. 1930



Carbolic soap, 1894

GERM-KILLING SOAP

In 1834, the German chemist Friedlieb Ferdinand Runge discovered carbolic acid (or phenol)—the substance Lister used as an antiseptic. By the end of the 19th century, this antiseptic was widely available to the general public in the form of mass-produced soap bars.



Sterile padding absorbs blood.

STICKING BANDAGES

Until the early 20th century, applying a bandage to a small cut was a painstaking business that usually required two people. In 1920, Earl Dickson (an American inventor and employee of Johnson & Johnson) came up with a solution—adhesive bandages. These were small squares of bandage attached to a strip of sticky tape. Manufactured under the name Band-Aid, they are now used all over the world.

Face masks prevent doctors from spreading respiratory infections.



SAFE SURGERY

Modern surgeons take numerous precautions to protect against infections. These include wearing face masks, surgical caps, scrub suits (sanitary clothing), and latex gloves. Using antiseptics alongside these continues to help sanitize modern surgical spaces.

Sterile gloves are thrown away after one use.

WOW!

The mouthwash Listerine was named after Joseph Lister to highlight its antibacterial properties.